Another lasting experience was joining twenty-eight members of the Young Communist Labour Brigade in the far-flung Ural Mountains in Siberia to help build Magnitogorsk. It took four days by train from the capital to get to this vast new-fangled iron and steel combine, set to become the second greatest industrial district in the world. Honecker spoke often of his part in its development, describing working conditions as ‘incredibly difficult’, but he romantically recalled relaxed evenings when the working noise subsided, and the sound of Russian folk songs and refrains of the revolution wafted throughout the plant.

I remember it was terribly hot in Magnitogorsk, up to 40°C … There were neither trees nor greenery. We worked day and night, lived in tents and in the earth. We were housed in wooden barracks. The building was impressive, although there was no technology at the time – our muscles, that was all the technology.

He not once mentioned the 50,000 dispensable prisoners in a neighbouring camp used as forced labour on starvation rations. Even forty years later, Honecker only reminisced about the ‘heroic struggle with the pioneers of socialism’:

Where Magnitogorsk stands today there was nothing but bare, barren steppe forty years ago. Building on the foundation of Soviet power and led by their Leninist party, the Soviet workers and Komsomols built the new factories and the new residential section at the cost of tremendous effort and sacrifice. I have vivid memories of their heroism in those days,